The Illusion of the Given

Madhyamaka, Non-Foundational Dzogchen, and the Dissolution of the Referent

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Introduction: The Intersubjective Dilemma

When multiple observers gaze at the world and report concordant features, an instinctual metaphysical assumption is triggered: agreement must be anchored in a common, mind-independent referent standing behind appearances. If two humans observe a river, or if a human, an animal, and an insect navigate the same terrain, ordinary realism demands an underlying substrate—a physical, objective constant that each creature merely registers or filters through species-specific sensory hardware.

In classical Indo-Tibetan philosophy, this tension is crystallized in the famous analysis of the "one bowl of liquid":

- To a human, it appears as refreshing, thirst-quenching water.
- To a hungry ghost (*preta*), driven by karmic traces of deprivation, it appears as putrid pus and blood.
- To an aquatic creature, it appears as an ambient atmosphere and home.
- To a celestial being (*deva*), it appears as ambrosial nectar.
- To an awakened noble being (*ārya*), it appears as the pure radiance of Māmakī, the female Buddha of the water element.

The immediate impulse of classical realism is to interpret this variation through a dualistic or Kantian lens. One assumes that a neutral, uncarved "stuff-in-itself" (whether conceived as H_2O, bare matter, or raw physical energy) occupies the coordinate space, and that differing organisms merely apply distinct cognitive and biological filters to that pre-existing given.

Yet both orthodox Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka and non-foundational Dzogchen reject this assumption. When subjected to rigorous analysis, the hypothesis of an inherently established common basis (*gzhi mthun rang bzhin gyis grub pa*) collapses. Furthermore, this deconstructive stance finds resonances—not proofs—in contemporary physics and philosophy of science, specifically Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics (RQM) and Karen Barad's Agential Realism. They are used here as illustrations. Read as ontologies in which relations are what is really there, they would only install a new floor.

Agreement does not require an ultimate substrate. Regularity does not require a foundational floor. When conditions vary, appearances shift not because observers decode a single, uncarved given differently, but because objects, observers, and channels of interaction are designated together within dependent arising. The relations are as unfindable as the things related.

1. The Trap of the Uncarved Substratum

The claim that "different species see the same liquid differently" smuggles in an unexamined noun: *the liquid*. It presumes that prior to any perceptual encounter, an entity already stands in quiet self-possession, waiting to be evaluated.

This is the classic retreat into Kantian transcendental idealism:

- **The Postulate:** A *Ding an sich* (thing-in-itself) exists beyond cognition, while organisms merely stamp subjective categories, spatial coordinates, and sensory modalities onto it.
- **The Madhyamaka Critique:** If this underlying substrate exists prior to and independent of being perceived, what are its actual attributes? If it has specific properties (such as thirst-quenching water), it cannot explain the preta's direct, functional encounter with burning pus. If it has no properties whatsoever, an uncharacterized, property-less substrate cannot act as an efficient cause (*arthakriyā*) to trigger any sensory cognition at all.[1]

The "Wet-and-Moist" (*rlan gsher*) Counter-Argument

A thoughtful objector will immediately resist this dilemma: "Why assume the substrate must be water or pus? Why couldn't it be 'the wet-and-moist' (*rlan gsher*)—a basic physical property common to both water and pus?"

It is a natural candidate. In Abhidharma, wetness and moisture (*rlan zhing gsher ba*) is the defining mark of the water element, common to whatever is liquid. But this move faces a critical fork:

1. **If *rlan gsher* is claimed as an inherently existent substrate:** The argument fails. A generic, uninstantiated "wetness" is a conceptual generality (*spyi*). In concrete reality, wetness never exists in the abstract; it exists only as *this* consumable water, *this* caustic pus, or *this* ambient aquatic medium. Moreover, physical fluidity is itself a relational encounter: what registers as fluid to macro-biological organisms with cell membranes does not function as fluid to systems operating at different scales or through different forces.
2. **If *rlan gsher* is claimed as a conventional common basis (*tha snyad kyi gzhi mthun*):** It is no longer an uncarved thing-in-itself. It becomes a prime example of an acceptable **nominal basis**—a functional, provisional designation that allows human debaters to coordinate and discuss different perspectives without pretending to point to an ultimate, observer-independent floor.

As Nāgārjuna demonstrates throughout the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* (MMK), the target of deconstructive analysis is ***svabhāva***—intrinsic reality, self-nature, or non-dependent being. An uncarved "neutral substrate" posited beneath appearances is simply *svabhāva* wearing an agnostic disguise.

2. Intersubjectivity Without a Substrate: The Prāsaṅgika Model

If there is no inherently established referent behind appearances, why do humans consistently agree that the liquid is water? Why doesn't the conventional world dissolve into arbitrary fantasy?

[1] Kant never treats the thing-in-itself as an empirical cause within experience, though he calls it the "non-sensible cause" of appearances (A494/B522), the root of the objection Jacobi pressed. And while Prāsaṅgikas accept *arthakriyā* (functional efficacy) only provisionally within unanalyzed worldly convention without adopting Dharmakīrti's criterion of ultimate reality, the epistemological point holds: a substrate stripped of all relational determinations can provide neither causal purchase nor explanatory leverage.

In Chapter 6 of the *Madhyamakāvatāra*, Candrakīrti provides the Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka answer: **agreement does not prove an underlying substrate; shared conventional coherence is the very definition of conventional truth (*saṃvṛtisatya*).**

A. Mutual Dependence (*Parasparāpekṣā*)

Candrakīrti spends substantial effort (roughly MA 6.45–97; verse numbers here follow La Vallée Poussin's edition, and some translations number one lower) dismantling the idealist (*Cittamātra* / Mind-Only) position, which seeks to solve the problem by eliminating external matter and making an intrinsically real consciousness (*vijñāna*) the sole ground. Candrakīrti demonstrates that mind and object (*viṣaya*) stand in a relationship of strict mutual dependence:

- A perceiving consciousness cannot be established without reference to an object.
- An object cannot be established without reference to the perceptual and conceptual framework that delineates it.

Neither consciousness nor matter enjoys ontological priority. To make mind the foundational container is just as mistaken as making physical matter the container.

B. Sound Faculties vs. Impairment Within Designated Classes

Candrakīrti distinguishes what the world itself takes as true from what even the world takes as false, according to whether the sense faculties are unimpaired or impaired, for instance by the eye disease *timira* (MA 6.24–25). Later authors call the two correct and erroneous convention (*tathya-* and *mithyā-saṃvṛti*). The standard illustrations are the white conch seen as yellow with jaundice, and the falling hairs seen with *timira*.

Crucially, **impairment is defined strictly within a biological or karmic class:**

- The human with jaundice sees a white conch as yellow. Because other humans with sound visual faculties see it as white, the jaundiced human is conventionally mistaken by human standards.
- The preta, however, is not a "jaundiced human." Relative to the preta's own karmic conditioning, its faculties are unimpaired *by preta standards*. It is not suffering an optical illusion of water; the substance genuinely functions as pus within its operative conventionality.

Furthermore, this sorting into correct and erroneous is made **from the standpoint of the world (*lokaprasiddha*)**. In his commentary on MA 6.28, Candrakīrti says that noble beings (*āryas*), having abandoned afflictive ignorance, see compounded things as like reflections: for them these are "mere conventionalities" (*saṃvṛtimātra*), not truths.

C. A Nominal Observed Basis (*dmigs gzhi tsam*)

To avoid collapsing into nihilism (*ucchedavāda*), this article draws a distinction in the spirit of Tsongkhapa's reading. In his commentary on MA 6.71 (*Illuminating the Intent*), the preta's perception of the river as pus is treated as a conventional perception conditioned by karma, not as a mere error. The Tibetan terms in the table below are the article's own analytic terms, not a formula quoted from a Gelug text. The wider question, how beings of different realms perceive what is for us one entity, is studied by Dorji Wangchuk (2009) and in Jacob Fisher's *Nectar, Water, or Blood?* (2025), which ends with Tsongkhapa's much-debated reading of the example.

Table 1. The common basis: what is negated and what is accepted

What Is Negated	What Is Conventionally Accepted
An intrinsically established common basis (*gzhi mthun rang bzhin gyis grub pa*): a mind-independent physical substance possessing its own ontological identity prior to perception.	A mere nominal observed basis (*dmigs gzhi tsam* / *snang gzhi tsam*): a dependently designated convergence point where different karmic appearances meet.

What prevents this *dmigs gzhi tsam* from collapsing back into a Kantian *Ding an sich*?

The observed basis is not a bearer of properties that precedes its relations. It has no characteristics beyond those that hold relative to some channel of coupling. It is a designation made from within a particular conventional frame, usually the human one (*tha snyad pa'i tshad ma*), which lets different perspectives be referred to one another. Its job is to coordinate, not to underlie. It does in Madhyamaka what cross-perspective coordination does in relational quantum mechanics, not what a substance does in classical realism.

D. The Bowl's First Owner: Vasubandhu, and Candrakīrti's Reply

The bowl did not begin as a Madhyamaka example. In his *Twenty Verses* (*Viṃśikā*, v. 3), Vasubandhu uses the hungry ghosts to answer an objection to Mind-Only. If there are no external objects, why do appearances agree? Why do many beings see the same thing, at the same place and time? His reply: just as hungry ghosts with similar karma together see a river of pus, so the shared ripening of karma in consciousness accounts for shared appearances. No river outside the mind is needed.

That is this article's question, answered by making consciousness the floor. Candrakīrti's examination of Mind-Only (roughly MA 6.45–97) turns the example around. At MA 6.71 he takes up the preta who sees the river as pus, likens it to the vision of someone with an eye disease, and concludes that as the object does not exist, neither does the mind. If the pus has no standing because it is not external, the cognition of pus has no better standing, since object and cognition are designated together (§2A). For the preta, the river of pus and the seeing of it stand or fall together. The rest of his argument draws the conventional side: in the world's terms both the object and the mind are accepted, and under analysis neither is found. So the bowl does not show that the world is in the mind. It shows that neither the world nor the mind is the floor. Shared karma, as karmic vision (*las snang*), remains part of the account of agreement, but as a condition among conditions, not as a storehouse consciousness in which appearances are really kept.

3. Other Observers

Agreement presupposes others to agree with. Three questions follow: how other observers are known at all, whether the account of agreement is circular, and what part language plays.

A. Other Minds

Intersubjectivity assumes there are other observers whose appearances could agree with mine. How is that known? Buddhist epistemology treated this as a question in its own right. Dharmakīrti's *Proof of Other Mental Continua* (*Santānāntarasiddhi*) argues by inference: other bodies act and speak with purpose, as mine does when I intend something, so other streams of mind are inferred from their activity. Ratnakīrti, writing later on Mind-Only premises, answered with a *Refutation of Other Mental Continua* (*Santānāntaradūṣaṇa*), arguing that other minds cannot finally be established.

Both texts share an assumption that this article rejects: my own stream is given, and others are inferred or doubtful. Madhyamaka refuses the asymmetry. My mental continuum is no more found under analysis than yours; both are designated in dependence on aggregates, and both function. The certainty I feel about "my" experience and the doubt I feel about "yours" are the substantialist habit turned inward, making the self the one indubitable floor (Book 4, Chapter 1). Conventionally, the world acknowledges other minds as plainly as it acknowledges tables, and no valid conventional cognition contradicts it. Other observers are not a conclusion drawn from a private starting point. They are designated together with this one, as long and short are.

B. Is Agreement Circular?

A critic can press §2B. Faculties count as sound when they agree with others of their class, and the class is defined by sharing those faculties. Standards set the class, and the class sets the standards. Is the account circular?

It is, and the circle is not a defect. It would be fatal only if agreement had to rest on something outside itself: a final certifier that is not one more participant. Madhyamaka denies there is one. The mutual dependence here is the same structure as means and objects of knowledge, each established only in relation to the other (Book 4, Chapter 5). Nothing is being derived from a foundation, so there is no foundation for the circle to lack. Wittgenstein reached a similar point from another direction. What makes rule-following possible is agreement "not in opinions but in form of life" (*Philosophical Investigations* §241); and "if language is to be a means of communication there must be agreement not only in definitions but also (queer as this may sound) in judgments" (§242). Agreement is not evidence of an object behind it (Book 2, "The Formation of a Mountain"). It is the convention working.

The circle does not make error impossible. Within it, correction is real: the jaundiced eye is corrected by others, a misreading by a second look. What the circle rules out is only a correction from outside every frame.

C. Language

For human beings the frame that does the bookkeeping is, to a large degree, a language. Designations are learned from others, corrected by others and shared with others. A child learns "water" as a word that works: when it is said, a glass is brought. That is why humans agree so finely, not only that the liquid is there, but that it is water, that it is cold, and that it is the same water as yesterday's.

Designation is wider than language (Book 4, Chapter 6). Animals designate by perception and response, without words, and their worlds are coordinated too. But language carries the human circle of agreement across times and places that no single perception could reach. It is also where the substantialist habit is most fluent: the noun "the bowl" seems to point to something standing behind every view of it (§1). The same tool that coordinates human worlds tempts us to believe it describes the one world behind them.

4. The Phenomenological Shift: Non-Foundational Dzogchen

While Prāsaṅgika-Madhyamaka uses relentless dialectics to deconstruct metaphysical claims and halt analysis at worldly convention, the Great Perfection (Dzogchen) describes how appearances are met in experience, in a phenomenological vocabulary.

A. The Basis (*gzhi*) Is Not an Ontological Substrate (*kun gzhi*)

In the non-foundational lineages of Dzogchen—illuminated by Longchenpa in his *Seven Treasuries* and clarified by Ju Mipham Rinpoche—the basis (*gzhi*), primordially pure, is carefully distinguished from the *ālaya* / *kun gzhi* (the karmic substrate storehouse):

- The basis is described through three inseparable aspects: its essence (*ngo bo*), empty, which is **primordial purity** (*ka dag*); its clarity (*rang bzhin*, often translated "nature"), which is **spontaneous presence** (*lhun grub*), appearing unobstructed; and **compassion** (*thugs rje*). This article takes up only the first two. It does not gloss *thugs rje* as a cosmic force or as a responsiveness belonging to the basis.
- Primordial purity means that the basis is thoroughly devoid of substantial reality (*svabhāva*). It is not an uncarved block, a cosmic mind, or a metaphysical origin. Longchenpa says the basis is called a ground only from a relative point of view; in the true nature of things it is empty of being one, free from all extremes (*mtha' bral*). "True nature" here means only the way things are, not an essence.

B. Self-Display (*rang snang*): Mind (*sems*) versus Awareness (*rig pa*)

Appearances are spoken of as display (*rtsal*, *rol pa*), manifesting as **self-display** (*rang snang*). "Display" must not be heard as the display of something standing behind it. It means dependent arising, vivid and unobstructed, with nothing behind it.

To prevent this from sliding back toward mentalism or making consciousness the hidden source of the world, Dzogchen's own distinction between dualistic mind (*sems*) and pure awareness (*rig pa*) is essential:

- **The Subject Pole is Part of the Display:** Dualistic consciousness (*sems*)—the interior subject that grasps—is itself an appearance, arising symmetrically alongside the external object (*yul*). Neither mind nor matter is the source of the other; both are co-emergent polarities within the display.
- **Awareness Is Not a Radiating Container:** Rigpa (*rig pa*) is not one half of this subject–object pair, nor a subtle mental substance that projects outer forms, nor a ground behind appearing. It is taken here as the knowing of the basis: recognising appearing as unfixed, dependent and empty. The clarity of appearing (*rang bzhin gsal ba*) is the appearing's own, not light borrowed from a knower, and like the appearing it is empty (*ngo bo stong pa*).
- **Display is Not Causal Production:** The basis does not "generate" appearances as a cause produces an effect. Spontaneous presence (*lhun grub*) is not an unconditioned creative source churning out conditioned objects. Rather, appearing is already complete, owing its completeness to nothing hidden, and it is empty from the very moment it appears.

C. Reflexive Awareness (*rang rig*): A Deliberate Shift in Framework

This brings the synthesis to a major historical divide. In *Madhyamakāvatāra* 6.72ff, Candrakīrti rejects reflexive awareness (*svasaṃvedana* / *rang rig*), citing the *Ratnacūḍa-sūtra*. Śāntideva later made the argument famous in *Bodhicaryāvatāra* 9.17–18: an entity cannot act upon itself, just as a sword cannot cut its own blade. Following Candrakīrti, Tsongkhapa makes the rejection of *rang rig* even conventionally one of his Eight Difficult Points (*dka' gnas brgyad*, also spelled *dka' gnad*).

Here, **the synthesis explicitly follows Ju Mipham Rinpoche rather than Tsongkhapa:**

- **Ultimately:** Mipham completely affirms the Prāsaṅgika refutation. Under ultimate analysis (*paramārtha-vicāra*), no intrinsically established awareness or reflexive knowing can be found. *Rang rig* is empty of inherent existence.
- **Conventionally:** Mipham defends *rang rig* within conventional discourse (*tha snyad*) to account for memory and immediate cognitive experience without spawning an infinite regress of secondary witness-consciousnesses. This is not the Yogācāra self-awareness Candrakīrti refuted, which was offered as proof of a really existing, other-dependent consciousness. Mipham's *rang rig* is a convention, and empty like every convention.
- In Dzogchen, the self-knowing of *rig pa* is not an intrinsically real subject knowing itself as an intentional object. It is the natural absence of delusion (*ma rig pa*): the immediate, unconstructed lucidity of recognising appearing as empty display, belonging to no one.

This reading of Mipham is the author's, from repeated study of the *Beacon of Certainty* and his commentary on Śāntarakṣita's *Madhyamakālaṃkāra*. *The Observer and the Taste of Presence* (Chapter 19) presents the Mipham, Gorampa and Higgins readings as open. This article takes Mipham's side on the conventional status of self-knowing, and on that point only.

D. Mipham's Fourfold Epistemology and Pure Vision (*dag gzigs*)

Mipham organizes valid cognition (*pramāṇa*) into a fourfold framework:

1. **Impure Conventional Valid Cognition (*tshur mthong tshad ma*):** Operates within samsaric karmic vision (*las snang*), bound by habitual traces (*bag chags*). **Devas belong here:** their experience of liquid as nectar is an elevated karmic vision, not awakened pure vision.
2. **Pure Conventional Valid Cognition (*dag gzigs kyi tshad ma*):** Belonging to noble beings (*āryas*), where the liquid appears with specific conventional content: **Māmakī, the female Buddha of the water element**.
3. **Categorized Ultimate Valid Cognition (*rnam grangs pa'i don dam*):** The analytical realization of emptiness arrived at through intellectual negation.
4. **Uncategorized Ultimate Valid Cognition (*rnam grangs min pa'i don dam*):** The non-conceptual, direct realization of the inseparable unity of primordial purity and spontaneous presence.

Connecting Horizontal Relativity and Vertical Ranking

How does this reconcile with Candrakīrti's horizontal conventionalism (§2B)?

Mipham holds both perspectives together: **Within impure vision (*tshur mthong*), validity is strictly relative to the class of beings.** The preta's vision of pus is unimpaired by preta standards; the human's vision of water is unimpaired by human standards. Neither has an absolute vantage over the other within the samsaric sphere. **Between impure and pure vision, however, there is a vertical ranking.** Pure-vision valid cognition assesses the authentic, where "how things appear" (*snang tshul*) concords with "how things actually are" (*gnas tshul*): *gnas snang mthun pa*.

Why Pure Vision Does Not Smuggle in a Foundation: Does *gnas snang mthun pa* re-introduce an objective ground? The crucial step is recognizing that **the pure vision of the mandala is itself empty—the inseparable union of appearance and emptiness (snang stong zung 'jug).** Pure vision is appearance without the obscuration of dualistic error (*'khrul pa*) and adventitious stains (*glo bur gyi dri ma*); it is not access to a metaphysical bedrock behind appearance. In Mipham's presentation, pure vision meets appearances as the mandala of deities and wisdoms. This article does not read that as qualities already present in a ground, waiting to be uncovered. It reads it as how ap-

pearing is met when nothing in it is being fixed. Because the deity Māmakī is completely devoid of inherent existence (*svabhāva*), pure vision is accurate not because it finds an ultimate object, but because it experiences appearance without the reifying distortion that splits reality into independ ent subjects and solid, external things.

5. Resonances in Physics: Rovelli, Barad, and Cross-Perspective Consistency

This dissolution of the given without falling into subjective idealism has resonances in contemporary physics and philosophy of science. They are resonances, not proofs. Emptiness does not need physics, and a physical description is itself a designation, one of the most reliable we have within its domain.

Karen Barad's Agential Realism

In *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, Karen Barad replaces classical *interaction* with ***intra-action***:

- **No Pre-existing Relata:** Traditional metaphysics presumes independent entities that subsequently interact. In agential realism, relata do not pre-exist their intra-action; they emerge through it.
- **The Agential Cut:** Boundaries and properties are enacted through specific material-discursive apparatuses. The cut does not slice up a pre-existing reality; it enacts what counts as the "observer" and what counts as the "observed" within a specific phenomenon.

There is no "liquid" standing prior to the cut. The human-as-drinker and the liquid-as-water co-emerge within human physiological-cultural intra-action. The preta-as-sufferer and the liquid-as-pus co-emerge within the preta karmic intra-action.

Carlo Rovelli's Relational Quantum Mechanics (RQM) and Cross-Perspective Links

In RQM, variables do not take values absolutely; they take values **only relative to another physical system during an interaction**.

The Cross-Perspective Links Postulate: Early formulations of RQM faced a serious challenge: if all physical facts are strictly relative to individual systems, what prevents the universe from frac turing into solipsistic, isolated reality-fragments? Why do two observers agree when they compare notes? Critics, among them Jacques Pienaar (2021), argued that the original theory lacked a built-in guarantee of consistency between observers.

In response, Emily Adlam and Carlo Rovelli (2023; preprint 2022) introduced the **Cross-Perspective Links (CPL)** postulate: if system O interacts with system S and registers a value, and observer O' subsequently interacts with both O and S to verify the result, the measurement outcome registered by O' will match the record of O, provided O's record has not been destroyed.

Some critics, such as Peter Lewis and Marcin Markiewicz with Marek Żukowski, argue that CPL gives up what made the theory distinctively relational, conceding shared facts across perspectives. This is less a concession than a confirmation of the point made here: agreement between two observers does *not* require an unmeasured, classical state to have existed prior to interaction. Rather, agreement is established via physical interaction channels between the observers themselves. Intersubjective coherence is produced through horizontal relational coordination and cross-checking—a close counterpart of Candrakīrti's corroboration among sound faculties (§2B)—not by anchoring to an absolute classical substrate.

One caution governs this whole section. Neither RQM nor agential realism should be read as saying that relations are what is really there. Barad makes the phenomenon the primary ontological unit; read as an ontology, that repeats at the level of relation the substantialism it set out to overcome. Nāgārjuna examined connection itself: "coming into contact, having come into contact, and the one who brings them into contact are not found" (MMK 14.8). Relations and relata are designated together; neither is prior, and neither is the ground. What the physics offers is an illustration of agreement without a pre-existing common object, not a new floor made of relations.

6. Differential Coupling and Relational Affordances

If an appearance requires a specific configuration of faculties, conditions, and interaction channels, what occurs when a class of beings encounters an environmental region with which it shares **little or no coupling**?

The answer is neither an "absolute ontological zero" (which lapses into subjective solipsism and erases conventional reality) nor an uncarved classical object (which lapses into foundationalism). Rather, **relational coupling comes in degrees, and the facts that hold relative to a system track precisely which physical and cognitive channels are coupled.**

A. Uexküll's *Umwelt* and Causal Blind Spots

In biosemiotics, Jakob von Uexküll demonstrated that an organism does not experience a generic environment, but rather an ***Umwelt***—a functional world carved out by its sensory-effector loops:

- The common tick responds primarily to three signals: butyric acid, the warmth of a mammal's body, and hair.
- A pool of clear spring water lacks these semiotic triggers. To the tick, the water does not appear as an affordance; it does not exist within the tick's perceptual map.

However, the water is not an "ontological zero" for the tick: **the tick can still drown in the water**. The tick is uncoupled from the optical and semiotic channels of the water, but it remains coupled to its fluid dynamics and surface tension. This demonstrates why conventional reality is not relativized to a private mind: causal impact (*arthakriyā*) operates along specific relational channels regardless of whether an organism has conceptual or perceptual awareness of it.

B. Differential Coupling in Physics

Physical systems reveal this same tiered relationality:

- **The Gravitational Channel:** As far as current observation shows, dark matter does not couple to the electromagnetic force, so it passes through the Earth without collision or resistance. To an electromagnetic sensor the Earth is an impenetrable barrier; to dark matter that barrier does not exist. Yet its trajectory is bent by the Earth's mass: it is coupled through gravity.
- **The Neutrino:** A solar neutrino crosses vast expanses of lead with an extraordinarily low chance of interacting. The lead is neither a wall nor nothing; it is a region of very weak coupling.

C. Classical Parallels: Non-Obstruction and the Absence of Affordances

This continuum of coupling resolves the classical Buddhist accounts without demanding an uncarved substrate:

- **Subtle spirits passing through mountains:** Spirits whose karmic bodies share no coarse elemental density pass unobstructed through rock faces. Solidity is not an intrinsic property of the stone; it is a relational resistance actualized only when two systems of similar physical density collide.
- **The Formless Realm (*Ārūpyadhātu*):** Beings in formless meditative states have deactivated coarse sensory aggregations; physical affordances are completely inoperative relative to their cognitive frame.

The bowl of liquid remains a **nominal observed basis (*dmigs gzhi tsam*)**. It is not erased from conventional existence merely because an uncoupled observer fails to register it. But what appears there—an impenetrable barrier, fluid nourishment, burning pus, or an uncoupled passage—depends entirely on the channels enacted in the encounter. The "basis" is only the human frame's name for the place where these appearances are compared. It is not something underneath that manifests as them.

D. Across Realms: The Water Offering

The hardest test of the thesis is interaction between worlds, and Buddhist practice assumes it. In offerings of water and food to hungry ghosts, a practitioner blesses water with mantra and gives it, and the tradition holds that it reaches the pretas as nectar. The East Asian rite rests on the *Sūtra of the Dhāraṇī for Rescuing the Flaming-Mouth Hungry Ghost*, translated by Amoghavajra (Taishō 1313), in which the dhāraṇī turns food into nectar for them. If each realm's world arises within its own karmic vision, how can an act in one reach another?

Not by a substance that travels. Nothing passes from the human bowl into the preta's mouth, any more than the flame at dusk rides into the flame at midnight (*The Architecture of Carrierless Continuity*). The giving is designated in the human frame: water, a mantra, an intention. The relief is designated in the preta's frame: nectar where there was pus. The two are linked by dependent arising, as condition in one frame and result in another, and the link is recorded from the frame of the one who gives, the frame that can compare them. This is the structure of the cross-perspective links of §5: agreement and influence across perspectives, with no common object underneath.

Two cautions. The article does not claim to have verified the efficacy of such practices; it asks only what the tradition's claim would mean without a substrate. And the mantra is not a power residing in sounds, any more than the power to open resides in a key apart from the lock, the hand and the door (Book 4, Chapter 5). It is one condition among conditions, effective, if at all, in the way conditions are.

7. The Dissolution of the Container Myth

Why does realism so persistently cling to an underlying object? The root obstacle is the **Container Myth** (the Cartesian and Newtonian intuition of absolute space and time):

1. We imagine space as an empty, pre-existing three-dimensional container.
2. We place a solid object in the center of the room.
3. We place observers inside the container and assume they must either interact with the pre-existing object or suffer an illusion.

Modern physics and Madhyamaka dismantle this container:

- **General Relativity and Quantum Gravity:** In Einstein's physics, spacetime is not an empty stage; **spacetime is the gravitational field itself**—a dynamic physical entity that interacts with matter and energy. In loop quantum gravity, spin networks describe quantized states of the gravitational field itself; space has discrete quanta and emerges relationally.
- **Madhyamaka Deconstruction:** In MMK Chapter 5 (*Analysis of the Elements / Dhātuparīkṣā*), Nāgārjuna demonstrates that space (*ākāśa*) cannot exist prior to its defining characteristics (such as non-obstruction). Space and the entities within it are co-dependent designations.

When space ceases to be an absolute warehouse, the puzzle of how an object can appear differently across species dissolves. Space, time, observer and observed are designated together, and none is the container of the others. The "web" that links them is a designation too, not a further thing.

8. The Question of Regularity: Why Is There a Coherent Web?

This brings the inquiry to the fundamental question that realism poses against a view without a foundation: "If there is no ultimate, objective ground, why is there an orderly, reliable web of conditions at all? Why do conditions cohere into predictable laws, regularities, and repeatable experiences rather than collapsing into chaotic noise?"

Foundationalist thought presumes this question requires an ultimate metaphysical ground—a prime mover, an absolute law, or a fundamental material substratum. Madhyamaka and non-foundational Dzogchen address this through two distinct, complementary moves:

A. The Conventional Answer: Dependent Regularity (*Idaṃpratyayatā*)

Conventionally, Madhyamaka does not leave regularity unexplained. Regularity is accounted for by the lawful nature of dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*):

- Causes produce concordant effects: barley seeds produce barley, not rice; fire burns and does not freeze.
- In the realm of sentient experience, collective karma (*sādhāraṇa-karma*) and shared evolutionary conditioning constrain how appearances unfold.
- Convention has its own robust, operational validity. To say a convention is empty of inherent existence does not mean it is arbitrary or lawless. Emptiness is not the negation of cause and effect. Nor is it what makes cause and effect work: **emptiness enables nothing and explains nothing.** The point runs the other way. Function never needed an essence, and a thing with an essence of its own could not arise, change or cease (MMK 24.16–20).

B. The Dialectical Deconstruction: Rejecting the Premise

When pressed further—"Yes, but why is there a web as a whole?"—the question makes a subtle category error by treating the entire web of dependent arising as if it were a single, bounded entity requiring an external cause.

1. **"The Web as a Whole" is a Nominal Designation:** A totality or "system as a whole" does not exist as an independent entity standing alongside its parts. It is a conceptual imputation (*prajñapti*). To demand an external ground for the "whole" is to seek a foundation outside of all relations.

2. **Infinite Regress vs. No Foundation:** If you posit an ultimate foundation X to explain the web, X must either be conditioned (requiring its own prior cause, continuing the chain) or unconditioned (which, lacking relations, cannot causally interact with or generate conditioned appearances). In MMK Chapter 11 (*Analysis of Prior and Posterior Extremes*), Nāgārjuna shows that dependent arising is beginningless (*anādikāla*). An infinite series of conditions is an ontological failure only if one is seeking a foundational resting place. Once no foundational resting place is being sought, the absence of a first beginning is no defect. It is simply what dependent arising looks like when no ground is demanded of it.

The question does not uncover a hidden substrate; **the question exhausts its own conceptual momentum.**

Conclusion: Functioning Without a Foundation

To recognize that similar beings see a similar world because they share similar conditions—and not because of a mind-independent given—is not a descent into nihilism or solipsism.

- It does not collapse into **idealism**, because the mind is just as empty, conditioned, and dependently arisen as the objects it encounters.
- It does not collapse into **subjective relativism**, because conventional truth operates with lawful, intersubjectively verifiable regularity (*arthakriyā*) across shared channels of coupling.

What is eliminated is solely the metaphysical anxiety that demands a foundation—the insistence that beneath the vibrant display of appearances, there must be a dead, unmoving, objective ballast keeping everything upright.

The view has a consequence beyond epistemology. If the preta's pus is pus for the preta, its suffering is not a mistake to be explained away from a human vantage. No frame owns the real world, so no being's world can be dismissed as merely its own. This is not relativism: impairment is still corrected within a frame, and pure vision is still less obscured than impure. But it is why compassion makes sense without a self behind it. Other beings' worlds are as valid for them as this one is for us, and emptiness takes nothing away from their suffering, or from the wish to relieve it.

In the Prāsaṅgika dialectic, the absence of a foundation takes nothing away from conventional efficacy. Nāgārjuna's verb is *yujyate*, "fits" or "works":

> *sarvaṃ ca yujyate tasya śūnyatā yasya yujyate*
>
> "For whom emptiness is possible, everything is possible."
>
> — *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* 24.14

And from the experiential side of Dzogchen, when appearances are recognized as self-display (*rang snang*), with no inherent subject grasping at an inherent object, appearing is met as it always was: vivid, unproduced and not found. Conventional reality does not endure *in spite* of having no foundation, and it does not appear *because* it has none. It never needed one.